AQA GCSE English Language Paper 2: Writers' Viewpoints and Perspectives

These revision notes are for Dougie. They cover AQA GCSE English Language (8700) Paper 2, one section per question, with a final section on spelling, punctuation and grammar.

The paper in a nutshell. Paper 2 is a written exam lasting **1 hour 45 minutes**. It is worth **80 marks**, which is **50% of your GCSE**. It has two sections:

- **Section A: Reading** (40 marks, 25% of the GCSE). You read **two linked sources** on the same topic: one non-fiction text and one literary non-fiction text. One is from the **19th century** and the other is from either the **20th or 21st century**. You answer four questions on them.
- **Section B: Writing** (40 marks, 25% of the GCSE). You write your own text giving your viewpoint on the same theme. The task tells you the audience, purpose and form.

The sources are unseen, so you won't have read them before the exam. They could be journalism, articles, reports, essays, travel writing, accounts, sketches, letters, diaries, autobiography or biography.

Question	Marks	Assessment objective	What it tests	Suggested time (a suggestion, not an AQA rule)
1	4	AO1	Finding true statements in part of one source	About 5 minutes
2	8	AO1	Summarising differences across both sources	About 8 minutes
3	12	AO2	Analysing language in one source	About 12 minutes
4	16	AO3	Comparing writers' viewpoints and methods across both sources	About 20 minutes
5	40 (24 for content and organisation, 16 for technical accuracy)	AO5 and AO6	Writing your own viewpoint	About 45 minutes

The AQA specimen paper advises you to spend about 15 minutes reading the sources and all five questions, about 45 minutes on Section A and about 45 minutes on Section B. The minutes for each separate question in the table are only a suggestion to help you share out that time.

2.1 Question 1: True statements

What the question asks

Question 1 is the short warm-up question. It points you to a set part of one source and gives you a list of statements about it. In the AQA specimen paper it is worded like this:

- "Read again the first part of Source A from lines 1 to 15."
- "Choose four statements below which are TRUE."
- "Shade the boxes of the ones that you think are true."
- "Choose a maximum of four statements."

In the specimen there are eight statements, lettered A to H, and four of them are true.

Marks	4
Assessment objective	AO1: identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas. (Question 1 only tests this first part of AO1.)
What to do	Read only the lines you're given. Decide which statements the text shows to be true. Shade exactly four boxes.
Suggested timing	About 5 minutes. This is a suggestion, not an AQA rule.

Explicit means the text says it straight out. **Implicit** means the text suggests it, so you have to work it out. Question 1 can test both: in the specimen, one of the true statements was about the writer making a joke to hide something, which the text never says in plain words.

How it's marked

There are no levels for Question 1. The AQA mark scheme simply lists each statement as true (T) or false (F). Four statements are true and the question is worth 4 marks, so if you shade the four true ones you get all 4 marks.

That makes it the easiest 4 marks on the paper, as long as you read carefully and follow the instruction to choose a maximum of four.

How to do it

Step by step

1. **Find the lines.** Draw a bracket around the lines the question gives you (for example, lines 1 to 15). Anything outside those lines doesn't count.
2. **Read the lines once, all the way through.**
3. **Take each statement in turn.** Find the part of the text it is talking about and underline it.
4. **Check every word of the statement.** A statement can be nearly right but false because of one word, such as "always", "never", "very" or "everyone".
5. **For implicit statements, ask:** "Does the text clearly suggest this, even if it doesn't say it?" If yes, it's true.

6. **Put a tick or cross in pencil** next to each statement, then shade the four you're sure of.
7. **Count your shaded boxes.** There must be four, no more.

Words to know

Word	Meaning
Explicit	Stated clearly in the text.
Implicit	Suggested by the text, so you have to work it out.
Infer	To work out something the text suggests.

Worked example

Practice source (modern newspaper column)

Last summer I agreed, against every instinct, to take my two children camping. I am not an outdoors person. My idea of roughing it is a hotel without room service. Still, the children had begged for weeks, so I bought a tent that promised to 'pop up in seconds'. It did not. It took forty minutes, two arguments and a kind stranger from the next pitch to get it standing. That night it rained so hard that the tent sagged like a tired balloon. My son, who is eleven, declared it the best night of his life. I lay awake counting the drips. By morning I had to admit one thing: we had laughed more than we had in months.

Question: Choose four statements below which are TRUE.

- A: The writer enjoys outdoor activities.
- B: The children asked to go camping for a long time before the trip.
- C: The tent was quick and easy to put up.
- D: Someone outside the family helped to put up the tent.
- E: The weather was dry on the first night.
- F: The writer's son enjoyed the night.
- G: The writer slept well.
- H: The trip brought the family closer in some way.

Model answer

Shade **B, D, F and H**.

- A is false: "I am not an outdoors person."
- B is true: "the children had begged for weeks".
- C is false: it "took forty minutes, two arguments".
- D is true: "a kind stranger from the next pitch" helped.
- E is false: "it rained so hard".
- F is true: the son called it "the best night of his life".

- G is false: "I lay awake counting the drips."
- H is true, but it is implicit: the text never says "we grew closer", but "we had laughed more than we had in months" suggests it.

Why this scores full marks: exactly four boxes are shaded and all four are true. Each one was checked against a specific bit of the text. Statement H shows the skill of spotting an implicit idea: you have to read between the lines. Statement A is a trap for anyone guessing from the topic (people who go camping usually like the outdoors), which is why you always check the text and never your own assumptions.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Mistake:** shading more than four statements. **Fix:** the paper says "Choose a maximum of four statements". Count your boxes before you move on.
- **Mistake:** using information from outside the lines given. **Fix:** bracket the lines first and only use what's inside them.
- **Mistake:** missing the one word that makes a statement false. **Fix:** read every word of the statement, especially "always", "never", "very" and "all".
- **Mistake:** ignoring statements that are implied rather than stated. **Fix:** ask whether the text clearly suggests it. Implicit statements can be true.
- **Mistake:** using your own opinion or general knowledge. **Fix:** a statement is only true if this text shows it.
- **Mistake:** changing your mind and leaving it unclear which boxes you mean. **Fix:** make your final choice obvious. The paper tells you to cross through any work you don't want marked.
- **Mistake:** spending too long here. **Fix:** it is 4 marks; keep it to about 5 minutes (a suggestion) and save your time for the bigger questions.

Quick check

▼ **1. How many marks is Question 1 worth?**

4 marks.

▼ **2. What is the most statements you should shade?**

Four. The paper says "Choose a maximum of four statements."

▼ **3. Which assessment objective does Question 1 test?**

AO1, the first part: identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas.

▼ **4. What does "implicit" mean?**

Suggested by the text but not said straight out, so you have to work it out.

▼ **5. Can you use a detail from line 20 if the question says lines 1 to 15?**

No. Only use the lines the question gives you.

2.2 Question 2: Summary of differences

What the question asks

Question 2 is the first question that uses both sources. In the AQA specimen paper it is worded like this:

- "You need to refer to Source A and Source B for this question."
- "Use details from both Sources. Write a summary of the differences between [two people, places or things]."

In the specimen, the question asked for the differences between the two young people in the sources.

Marks	8
Assessment objective	AO1, both parts: identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas; select and synthesise evidence from different texts.
What to do	Find differences between the two sources on the focus in the question. Back each one with short quotations from both sources, and say what those details suggest (your inferences).
Suggested timing	About 8 minutes. This is a suggestion, not an AQA rule.

Synthesise means pulling information from two places and putting it together into one answer. Here, that means writing about both sources side by side, linked together.

Question 2 is about **what** the sources tell you, not **how** the writers use language. Language analysis belongs in Question 3.

How it's marked

The examiner reads your answer and places it in one of four levels.

Level	Marks	What the examiner is looking for
Level 4: perceptive summary	7 to 8	Sharp inferences from **both** sources that see beneath the surface. Quotations and details that are well chosen ("judicious") and on the focus of the question. Differences that show real insight.
Level 3: clear, relevant summary	5 to 6	Clear inferences from **both** sources. Clear, relevant quotations and details. Clear differences.
Level 2: some attempts at summary	3 to 4	Some attempt at inference from one or both sources. Some suitable quotations or details. Some differences.
Level 1: simple, limited summary	1 to 2	Retells the sources (paraphrase) instead of inferring. Simple references. A simple difference.

Level 0	0	No differences offered.

To reach the top of a level, your answer has to do everything listed for that level. To get into the bottom of a level, you need the level below plus at least one thing from that level. Notice that Levels 3 and 4 need inferences from **both** sources.

How to do it

Step by step

1. **Underline the focus.** If the question asks about the differences between two children, ignore everything else, such as the weather or the food, unless it tells you about the children.
2. **Read both sources** and highlight details about the focus. Use one colour for each source.
3. **Pair them up.** Find three differences where each source says something different about the same thing (for example, how free each child is).
4. **Write one paragraph per difference.** In each paragraph:
   - make a point about Source A with a short quotation;
   - say what it suggests (your inference);
   - use a contrast word such as "whereas", "however" or "in contrast";
   - make the matching point about Source B with a short quotation and inference.
5. **Use inference words:** suggests, implies, shows, hints, we can tell that.
6. **Stop when you've made three strong differences.** This is an 8-mark question.

Tip for the 19th-century source: the sentences are often long and the words old-fashioned. Read it a sentence at a time and ask "what is actually happening here?" before you look for differences.

Words to know

Word	Meaning
Summary	The main points, in your own words, with short quotations as proof.
Synthesise	Bring together information from both sources in one answer.
Inference	What you work out from a detail: what it suggests beyond what it says.
Paraphrase	Retelling in your own words without explaining what it suggests. On its own, it stays in Level 1.
Embedded quotation	A short quotation slipped inside your own sentence, for example: Eliza finds bathing 'most alarming'.

Contrast words for Question 2

whereas, however, in contrast, on the other hand, unlike, while, instead.

Worked example

Source A (21st century newspaper travel column)

By ten o'clock the beach was already packed. We squeezed our towels between a family playing loud music and a man asleep under a newspaper. The sea was grey and freezing, but my daughter ran straight in, screaming with delight, while I stood at the edge with my trousers rolled up, pretending I was not cold. Lunch was chips, eaten fast before the seagulls could steal them. Nobody cared what anyone looked like or what anyone wore. It cost us the train fare and a few pounds for ice cream, and on the way home my daughter fell asleep against my shoulder, still sandy, still smiling. Days out do not need to be perfect to be good.

Source B (19th century letter from a young woman to her mother)

My dearest Mother, I write to you from the coast, where Aunt has brought me for the improvement of my health. The doctor insists that the sea air will strengthen my chest, and I am to bathe each morning at seven o'clock precisely. I confess I find the business most alarming. One is carried into the water in a wooden hut upon wheels, and a stout woman, employed for the purpose, plunges one beneath the waves whether one wishes it or not. Aunt watches from the shore and will not permit me to walk upon the sands without my bonnet and gloves. I am obedient, but I own I should like to run, just once. Your affectionate daughter, Eliza

Question: You need to refer to Source A and Source B for this question. Use details from both Sources. Write a summary of the differences between the two young people's experiences of the seaside.

Model answer

The two young people are at the seaside for very different reasons. In Source A the visit is simply a fun day out, and the fact that it 'cost us the train fare and a few pounds for ice cream' suggests an ordinary, relaxed family treat. Eliza, however, has been taken to the coast 'for the improvement of my health', which implies the visit is more like a course of medicine than a holiday, and that adults have made the choice for her.

They also feel very differently about the sea itself. The daughter in Source A 'ran straight in, screaming with delight', so she is free to enjoy the water on her own terms. In contrast, Eliza finds bathing 'most alarming' because a woman 'plunges one beneath the waves whether one wishes it or not'. This suggests she has no control over her own body or her own day.

Finally, the adults treat them differently. The parent in Source A joins in, standing at the edge 'pretending I was not cold', which hints at a warm, playful relationship. Eliza's aunt only 'watches from the shore' and insists on 'bonnet and gloves', implying a strict guardian who cares more about rules and appearances than fun. When Eliza admits she 'should like to run, just once', we can tell how much she longs for the freedom the modern girl takes for granted.

Why this would score well (Level 4):

- It makes three clear differences, and every paragraph covers **both** sources.
- The quotations are short, embedded and well chosen.
- It goes beyond retelling: "more like a course of medicine than a holiday" and "no control over her own body" are perceptive inferences.
- It uses contrast words ("however", "in contrast") to link the sources.
- It stays on the focus (the young people's experiences) and doesn't drift into analysing language techniques, which earn nothing here.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Mistake:** summarising one source only. **Fix:** the question says "Use details from both Sources", and Levels 3 and 4 need inferences from both. Every paragraph should mention A and B.
- **Mistake:** analysing language (for example, "the writer uses a simile to..."). **Fix:** Question 2 tests AO1, not language. Say what the detail suggests about the people or situation, then move on.
- **Mistake:** writing about similarities. **Fix:** the question asks for differences. Stick to them.
- **Mistake:** retelling the story of each source. **Fix:** paraphrase alone stays in Level 1. Add an inference to every point: "this suggests...".
- **Mistake:** no quotations, or long ones. **Fix:** use short quotations of a few words, embedded in your sentences.
- **Mistake:** drifting away from the focus in the question. **Fix:** underline the focus and check every point against it.
- **Mistake:** writing far too much. **Fix:** three strong, linked differences is a good target for 8 marks.

Quick check

▼ **1. How many marks is Question 2 worth, and which AO does it test?**

8 marks; AO1 (both parts: identify and interpret information, and select and synthesise evidence from different texts).

▼ **2. What does "synthesise" mean?**

Bringing together information from both sources into one answer.

▼ **3. Should you write about the writer's use of language in Question 2?**

No. That is Question 3's job. Question 2 is about what the sources tell you and what that suggests.

▼ **4. What is the difference between paraphrase and inference?**

Paraphrase retells what the text says; inference explains what it suggests. Paraphrase alone is Level 1.

▼ **5. Name three words you can use to link the two sources.**

Any three of: whereas, however, in contrast, on the other hand, unlike, while, instead.

2.3 Question 3: Language analysis

What the question asks

Question 3 focuses on just one source. In the AQA specimen paper it is worded like this:

- "You now need to refer only to Source B, [a description of the source]."
- "How does [the writer] use language to [do something, such as try to influence someone]?"

In the specimen, Question 3 was about the 19th-century letter and asked how the writer used language to try to influence his father.

Marks	12
Assessment objective	AO2: explain, comment on and analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects and influence readers, using relevant subject terminology to support your views.
What it covers	The AQA mark scheme says this question assesses **language**: words, phrases, language features, language techniques and sentence forms.
What to do	Pick out language choices, quote them, name the technique where it helps, and explain the effect on the reader and how it helps the writer's purpose.
Suggested timing	About 12 minutes. This is a suggestion, not an AQA rule.

How it's marked

Level	Marks	What the examiner is looking for
Level 4: detailed, perceptive analysis	10 to 12	Analyses the effects of the writer's language choices in detail. A well-chosen ("judicious") range of quotations. Accurate and sophisticated use of subject terminology.
Level 3: clear, relevant explanation	7 to 9	Clearly explains the effects of language choices. A range of relevant quotations. Clear and accurate terminology.
Level 2: some understanding and comment	4 to 6	Attempts to comment on the effect of language. Some suitable quotations. Some terminology, mostly used correctly.
Level 1: simple, limited comment	1 to 3	Simple comments on effect. Simple references. Simple terminology, not always used correctly.
Level 0	0	No comments on the use of language.

To reach the top of a level, your answer has to do everything listed for that level. To get into the bottom of a level, you need the level below plus at least one thing from that level.

The mark scheme also says you don't need to know technical terms beyond those in the specification, but examiners do take into account when you use terms well to make your point

clearer and more precise. So a term helps only when you go on to explain its effect.

How to do it

Step by step

1. **Check which source.** The question says "refer only to Source..." Use only that one.
2. **Underline the focus**, for example "to try to persuade readers". Every point must link back to it.
3. **Pick four or five short quotations** from across the whole source: the start, middle and end.
4. **For each quotation, write a short paragraph that answers three questions:**
   - **What?** What has the writer used? Quote it and name the technique if you can.
   - **How?** What effect does it have on the reader? Zoom in on a single word and its connotations (the ideas and feelings it brings with it).
   - **Why?** How does this help the writer's purpose in the question?
5. **Go further where you can:** give a second meaning, or show how two choices work together.
6. **Write about language only.** Don't write about paragraph order or how the text is organised.

Language and rhetorical techniques you need

Term	What it means	Example
Direct address	Talking straight to the reader, usually with "you".	"You know this feeling."
Inclusive pronouns	"We", "us", "our": pulls the reader onto the writer's side.	"We all have a part to play."
Emotive language	Words chosen to make the reader feel strongly.	"helpless", "abandoned", "starving"
Rhetorical question	A question asked for effect, not for an answer.	"How much longer must we wait?"
Imperative	A command verb, telling the reader to do something.	"Imagine...", "Look around you."
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration.	"The queue stretched for miles."
Simile	A comparison using "like" or "as".	"The crowd moved like a slow river."
Metaphor	Saying something is something else.	"The classroom was a zoo."
Personification	Giving human qualities to something that isn't human.	"The wind howled at the door."
Repetition	Repeating a word or phrase for emphasis.	"Every day, every week, every year."

List of three (triplet)	Three items together for rhythm and force.	"cold, hungry and alone"
Alliteration	Words close together starting with the same sound.	"dark, dismal days"
Contrast (juxtaposition)	Placing opposite ideas close together.	"tiny hands" beside "huge machines"
Semantic field	A group of words linked to one topic.	"battle", "enemy", "defeat" (war)
Connotations	The ideas and feelings a word suggests beyond its meaning.	"Home" suggests safety and warmth.
Noun phrase	A noun with words that describe it.	"a cramped, airless room"
Word classes	Nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs. Name the class when you zoom in.	The verb "stormed" is more forceful than "walked".
Modal verbs	Must, should, could, will, might: show how certain or urgent something is.	"We must act now."
Proper nouns	Names of people, places, days and times. They make writing feel real and exact.	"Monday morning", "the High Street"
Tone	The attitude you can hear in the writing.	angry, sarcastic, nostalgic, hopeful, pleading
Register	How formal or informal the language is.	"I am most grateful" (formal) and "Cheers" (informal)
Irony and sarcasm	Saying the opposite of what you mean, often to mock.	"What a lovely surprise," she said, looking at the flood.
Anecdote	A short personal story used to make a point.	"When I was nine, I..."
Facts and statistics	Numbers and facts that make an argument seem reliable.	"twelve long hours"
Sentence forms	Short sentences for impact; long sentences to build up detail; questions; exclamations; commands.	"It did not."

Worked example

Source (19th century newspaper article)

Reader, I ask you to walk with me, at five o'clock on a winter's morning, through the black streets of our manufacturing towns. There you will see them: children of seven and eight years, barefoot upon the frozen stones, hurrying to the mill before the bell. They will stand at the roaring machines for twelve long hours. Their small fingers will be cut; their backs will be bent like old men's. For this they will be paid a few pennies, which their parents cannot afford to refuse. Is this the Christian nation of which we boast? Are these the comforts we purchase with our cheap cotton? It is a stain upon us all, and it must be washed away.

Question: You now need to refer only to the newspaper article above. How does the writer use language to try to persuade readers that the factory children need help?

Model answer

The writer begins with direct address and a request, 'Reader, I ask you to walk with me', which pulls the reader into the scene as if they are walking those 'black streets' too. The adjective 'black' suggests dirt and gloom, so before we even meet the children, the setting feels grim. Because the reader is made to feel like a witness, it is harder to ignore what follows.

The children are described with emotive detail. They are 'barefoot upon the frozen stones': 'barefoot' shows how poor they are, and 'frozen' makes the reader imagine the pain in their feet. The writer also gives their ages, 'seven and eight years', which stresses how young they are and makes the work seem crueller.

The machines are described as 'roaring', a verb that gives them the sound of a wild animal. Set against the children's 'small fingers', this contrast makes the children seem tiny and helpless beside something huge and dangerous. The simile 'their backs will be bent like old men's' is shocking because it suggests the work is stealing their childhood and ageing them before their time. Throughout this section the writer uses the future tense, 'will stand', 'will be cut', 'will be paid', which makes the suffering sound certain and endless, as if it will carry on every day unless someone acts.

Near the end, two rhetorical questions, such as 'Is this the Christian nation of which we boast?', aim to make readers feel guilty. The verb 'boast' hints that people are proud of their country while ignoring its faults. Finally, the metaphor of 'a stain upon us all' presents child labour as dirt on the whole nation. The inclusive phrase 'us all' means every reader shares the blame, and the modal verb 'must' in 'must be washed away' turns that guilt into a demand for action.

Why this would score well (Level 4):

- It picks a range of well-chosen quotations from the start, middle and end of the source.
- It uses terminology accurately (direct address, adjective, verb, simile, future tense, rhetorical question, metaphor, inclusive phrase, modal verb), and every term is followed by an explanation of its effect.

- It zooms in on single words ('black', 'frozen', 'roaring', 'boast') and explores their connotations.
- It shows how choices work together (the 'roaring' machines against 'small fingers').
- Every paragraph links back to the focus: persuading readers that the children need help.
- It sticks to language and sentence forms, which is exactly what the mark scheme says this question assesses.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Mistake:** writing about the wrong source, or both sources. **Fix:** the question says "refer only to Source..." Check the letter before you start.
- **Mistake:** technique spotting ("the writer uses a simile") with no explanation. **Fix:** every term must be followed by its effect on the reader and how it helps the writer's purpose.
- **Mistake:** writing about structure (paragraph order, how the text opens). **Fix:** the mark scheme says Question 3 assesses language: words, phrases, features, techniques and sentence forms.
- **Mistake:** vague comments like "it makes the reader want to read on" or "it creates a picture in your head". **Fix:** say exactly what the reader feels or thinks, and why that word causes it.
- **Mistake:** long quotations. **Fix:** quote a few words, then zoom in on one of them.
- **Mistake:** using only one or two quotations. **Fix:** the top levels reward a range of detail. Aim for four or five from across the source.
- **Mistake:** retelling what happens in the source. **Fix:** you're analysing how it is written, not what it says.
- **Mistake:** using the wrong term (for example, calling a simile a metaphor). **Fix:** if you're not sure of the term, describe the choice in plain words and explain its effect. A clear explanation beats a wrong label.

Quick check

▼ **1. How many marks is Question 3 worth, and which AO does it test?**

12 marks; AO2.

▼ **2. According to the mark scheme, what does Question 3 assess?**

Language: words, phrases, language features, language techniques and sentence forms.

▼ **3. What three questions should each paragraph answer?**

What has the writer used? How does it affect the reader? Why does it help the writer's purpose?

▼ **4. What are connotations?**

The ideas and feelings a word suggests beyond its basic meaning.

▼ **5. What is a rhetorical question?**

A question asked for effect, to make the reader think or feel something, not to get an answer.

2.4 Question 4: Comparing perspectives

What the question asks

Question 4 is the biggest reading question. It uses both whole sources. In the AQA specimen paper it is worded like this:

- "For this question, you need to refer to the whole of Source A, together with Source B."
- "Compare how the two writers convey their different attitudes to [a topic]."
- "In your answer, you could: compare their different attitudes; compare the methods they use to convey their attitudes; support your ideas with references to both texts."

In the specimen, the question asked about the writers' different attitudes to parenting and education.

Marks	16
Assessment objective	AO3: compare writers' ideas and perspectives, as well as how these are conveyed, across two or more texts.
What to do	Work out each writer's attitude (their viewpoint or perspective). Compare those attitudes, and compare the methods each writer uses to get them across. Use quotations from both sources.
Suggested timing	About 20 minutes. This is a suggestion, not an AQA rule.

The word "how" in the question is the important one: you are comparing **what** each writer thinks **and how** they show it.

How it's marked

Level	Marks	What the examiner is looking for
Level 4: perceptive, detailed	13 to 16	Compares the writers' ideas and perspectives perceptively. Analyses how the writers' methods are used. A range of well-chosen ("judicious") detail from both sources. A detailed understanding of the different ideas and perspectives in both.
Level 3: clear, relevant	9 to 12	Compares ideas and perspectives clearly. Clearly explains how methods are used. Relevant detail from both sources. A clear understanding of the different ideas and perspectives.
Level 2: some attempts	5 to 8	Attempts to compare ideas and perspectives. Some comment on methods. Some suitable detail from one or both sources, not always supporting the point. Identifies some different ideas.
Level 1: simple, limited	1 to 4	Simple cross-references between the sources. Simply names methods. Simple references from one or both sources. Simple awareness of ideas.
Level 0	0	No ideas about the differences.

To reach the top of a level, your answer has to do everything listed for that level. To get into the bottom of a level, you need the level below plus at least one thing from that level. Notice that every level mentions the writers' **methods**, not only their ideas.

How to do it

Step by step

1. **Underline the topic** in the question (for example, "attitudes to new technology").
2. **Sum up each writer's attitude in one sentence.** For example: "Writer A thinks it brings people together; Writer B thinks it destroys a way of life."
3. **Read the whole of both sources**, not just the first part. Highlight where each attitude shows, and how.
4. **Find three points of comparison.** Each should cover both writers and include a method, such as tone, form or a language choice.
5. **Write a short opening overview** that states both attitudes and how they differ.
6. **Write three comparing paragraphs.** In each: Writer A's attitude, method and quotation, with its effect; a comparative connective; Writer B's attitude, method and quotation, with its effect.
7. **Mention the time period, form and audience** where they help explain the difference (for example, a private letter and a public article).

Methods you can compare

Method	What to look for
Form	Is it a letter, article, diary, speech or essay? A letter is usually private; an article is public. The AQA mark scheme points to this kind of difference.
Audience and purpose	Who is it written for, and what does the writer want them to think or do?
Tone	Humorous, serious, angry, warm, nostalgic, sarcastic, anxious, admiring.
Register	Formal or informal, chatty or stiff.
Language choices	Imagery, emotive words, rhetorical questions, pronouns, contrast, repetition.
Structure	How it opens, where the tone shifts, how it ends.
Use of evidence	Personal stories (anecdotes), facts, references to their own time.
Time period	Language and values that reflect when it was written: old-fashioned politeness in the 19th century, modern references in the 20th or 21st.

Words to know

Word	Meaning

Attitude	What the writer thinks and feels about the topic.
Viewpoint or perspective	The writer's position: where they're coming from, shaped by who they are and when they lived.
Convey	Get across or show.
Methods	The tools a writer uses: form, tone, language and structure.

Comparative connectives

To show a difference	To show a similarity
whereas, however, in contrast, on the other hand, unlike, while, conversely, instead	similarly, likewise, both, in the same way, equally, also

Worked example

Source A (21st century newspaper article)

My grandmother is ninety-one, and until last month she had never sent a text. Then my cousin moved to Australia with her new baby, and Gran decided, with the stubbornness she is famous for, that she would learn to make video calls. The first attempt was a disaster: we spent ten minutes talking to her ear. But on Sunday, there it was on the screen, a tiny face in a knitted hat, waving a fist at a woman on the other side of the world. Gran cried. So did I. People love to complain that technology drives us apart. I have seen it do the opposite. It gave a ninety-one-year-old woman her great-granddaughter, live, at the touch of a button.

Source B (19th century letter to a newspaper)

Sir, I write to protest, in the strongest terms, against the proposed railway through our valley. For centuries this place has known no louder sound than the church bell and the lowing of cattle. Now we are told that an iron monster is to come roaring through our meadows at thirty miles an hour, belching smoke upon our crops and terrifying our horses. The gentlemen of the railway company speak of progress. I ask: progress for whom? Not for the farmer whose fields are cut in two, nor for the widow whose cottage is to be pulled down. Let them build their engines elsewhere. Some things, once lost, are never restored. I remain, Sir, your obedient servant, A Resident

Question: For this question, you need to refer to the whole of Source A, together with Source B. Compare how the two writers convey their different attitudes to new technology.

Model answer

Both writers respond to a new technology, but their attitudes are very different. The writer of Source A sees technology as something that brings families together, whereas the writer of Source B sees the railway as a destructive force that will ruin a peaceful community.

The modern writer conveys this warm attitude through a personal anecdote about a grandmother's first video call. Starting with the failure, 'we spent ten minutes talking to her ear', adds gentle humour and makes the technology seem harmless, even funny. In contrast, the letter writer presents the train as the metaphorical 'iron monster' that comes 'roaring through our meadows' and 'belching smoke'. These verbs are ugly and violent, showing fear and disgust, while Source A's 'tiny face in a knitted hat' is soft and loving. The two writers' word choices pull in opposite directions.

The writers also use their forms differently. Source A is an informal article, and the short sentences 'Gran cried. So did I.' share a private moment with a wide public audience, inviting readers to feel it too. On the other hand, Source B is a formal letter of protest, opening with 'Sir' and 'in the strongest terms'. This polite but firm register is typical of the 19th century and gives the writer's anger a serious, public weight.

Similarly, both writers appeal to the reader's emotions with vulnerable people, but for opposite purposes. Source A uses 'a ninety-one-year-old woman' to show technology giving something precious, while Source B uses 'the widow whose cottage is to be pulled down' to show technology taking things away. The letter writer then asks the rhetorical question 'progress for whom?' and ends with the command 'Let them build their engines elsewhere', leaving a sense of loss and defiance. Source A, however, ends on hope: 'at the touch of a button'. The difference may reflect their times: to a 19th-century farming valley the railway was new and frightening, whereas the modern writer has seen technology help.

Why this would score well (Level 4):

- The opening overview states both attitudes straight away, so the comparison is clear from the start.
- Every paragraph compares **both** ideas **and** methods: anecdote and humour against metaphor and personification, informal article against formal letter, two different uses of vulnerable people.
- It uses a range of short, well-chosen quotations from both sources, from beginning to end.
- It uses comparative connectives throughout ("whereas", "in contrast", "on the other hand", "similarly", "however").
- It notices a similarity in method (both appeal to emotion) used for different purposes, which is a perceptive point.
- It links the difference to the time period and form, which the mark scheme points to as methods worth comparing.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Mistake:** only comparing ideas and not methods. **Fix:** the question asks how the writers convey their attitudes. In every paragraph, name a method (tone, form, a language choice) and explain its effect.
- **Mistake:** writing all about Source A, then all about Source B, with no links. **Fix:** compare inside each paragraph using comparative connectives.

- **Mistake:** using only part of a source. **Fix:** the question says "the whole of Source A, together with Source B". Look at the ending of each source too.
- **Mistake:** treating it like Question 2 (a summary of differences). **Fix:** Question 4 is about attitudes and how they are shown, not just what each source says.
- **Mistake:** quoting from one source only. **Fix:** the higher levels need detail from both. Every paragraph should quote both.
- **Mistake:** describing the topic instead of the writer's attitude to it. **Fix:** keep asking "what does this writer think and feel about it?"
- **Mistake:** running out of time. **Fix:** it is 16 marks; about 20 minutes (a suggestion) is sensible, so keep an eye on the clock during Questions 1 to 3.

Quick check

▼ **1. How many marks is Question 4 worth, and which AO does it test?**

16 marks; AO3.

▼ **2. What two things must you compare?**

The writers' attitudes (ideas and perspectives) and the methods they use to convey them.

▼ **3. Do you use part of the sources or all of them?**

The whole of both sources.

▼ **4. Give two comparative connectives for a difference and two for a similarity.**

Difference: whereas, in contrast (or however, on the other hand, unlike). Similarity: similarly, likewise (or both, in the same way).

▼ **5. Name three methods you could compare.**

Any three of: form, audience and purpose, tone, register, language choices, structure, use of evidence, time period.

2.5 Question 5: Writing your viewpoint

What the question asks

Question 5 is the whole of Section B. It gives you a statement on the same theme as the Section A sources, then tells you what to write. In the AQA specimen paper it is worded like this:

- A statement in quotation marks giving a strong opinion (in the specimen, about homework).
- "Write an article for a broadsheet newspaper in which you explain your point of view on this statement."

The task always tells you the **audience** (who you're writing for), the **purpose** (for example, to explain, argue or persuade) and the **form** (for example, an article, letter, speech, leaflet or essay).

Marks	40 in total: **24 marks for content and organisation** (AO5) and **16 marks for technical accuracy** (AO6). Section B is 25% of your GCSE.
AO5	Communicate clearly, effectively and imaginatively, selecting and adapting tone, style and register for different forms, purposes and audiences. Organise information and ideas, using structural and grammatical features to support coherence and cohesion of texts.
AO6	Use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures for clarity, purpose and effect, with accurate spelling and punctuation.
What the paper tells you	"Write in full sentences." "You are reminded of the need to plan your answer." "You should leave enough time to check your work at the end." AQA advises about 45 minutes for Section B.
Suggested timing	Within the 45 minutes: about 5 to 10 minutes planning, about 30 minutes writing and about 5 minutes checking. This split is a suggestion, not an AQA rule.

How it's marked

Your writing gets two marks: one for content and organisation (out of 24) and one for technical accuracy (out of 16).

Content and organisation (AO5, 24 marks)

Content means how well your writing suits the audience and purpose, and your vocabulary and devices. **Organisation** means your ideas, structure, paragraphs and discourse markers (linking words such as "however" and "furthermore").

Level	Marks	Content	Organisation

Upper Level 4: compelling, convincing	22 to 24	Register is convincing and compelling for the audience; confidently matched to purpose; extensive, ambitious vocabulary; devices crafted all the way through.	Varied and inventive structure; compelling, with a range of convincing and complex ideas; fluently linked paragraphs with smoothly woven-in discourse markers.
Lower Level 4	19 to 21	Register convincingly matched to audience and purpose; extensive vocabulary; devices clearly crafted on purpose.	Varied, effective structure; highly engaging, with developed complex ideas; consistently coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers.
Upper Level 3: consistent, clear	16 to 18	Register consistently matched to audience and purpose; increasingly sophisticated vocabulary chosen for effect; a range of successful devices.	Effective structure; engaging, with a range of clear, connected ideas; coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers.
Lower Level 3	13 to 15	Register generally matched to audience and purpose; vocabulary clearly chosen for effect; appropriate devices.	Usually effective structure; engaging, with a range of connected ideas; usually coherent paragraphs with a range of discourse markers.
Upper Level 2: some success	10 to 12	Some sustained attempt to match register to audience and purpose; vocabulary chosen with care; some devices.	Some structural features; an increasing variety of linked, relevant ideas; some paragraphs and some discourse markers.
Lower Level 2	7 to 9	Attempts to match register to audience and purpose; begins to vary vocabulary; some devices.	Attempts structural features; some linked, relevant ideas; attempts paragraphs, with discourse markers not always used well.
Upper Level 1: simple, limited	4 to 6	Simple awareness of audience and purpose; simple vocabulary and devices.	Simple structural features; one or two relevant ideas, simply linked; paragraphs placed at random.
Lower Level 1	1 to 3	Occasional sense of audience and purpose; simple vocabulary.	Little or no structure; one or two unlinked ideas; no paragraphs.
Level 0	0	No meaningful writing to assess.	

Register means how formal or informal your writing is. Matching it to the audience is the first thing every level of content mentions.

Technical accuracy (AO6, 16 marks)

Level	Marks	In short
Level 4	13 to 16	Sentences always correctly marked; a wide range of punctuation used very accurately; a full range of sentence forms for effect; secure Standard English; very accurate spelling, including ambitious words; extensive, ambitious vocabulary.
Level 3	9 to 12	Sentences mostly correctly marked; a range of punctuation, mostly successful; a variety of sentence forms; mostly Standard English; generally accurate spelling, including complex and irregular words.
Level 2	5 to 8	Sentences mostly marked, sometimes accurately; some control of punctuation; attempts different sentence forms; some accurate spelling of complex words.
Level 1	1 to 4	Occasional sentence marking; some punctuation; simple sentences; basic spelling correct.

Section S of these notes covers technical accuracy in full.

How to do it

Step by step

1. **Decode the task.** Underline the form, the audience and the purpose. Write them at the top of your plan.
2. **Decide your viewpoint.** You can agree, disagree or partly agree. Pick the side you can argue best, and stick to it.
3. **Brainstorm ideas** for a couple of minutes: reasons, examples, a personal story, what the other side would say.
4. **Choose your best four or five ideas and put them in order.** A strong order is: hook, your viewpoint, your points (building to the strongest), the other side and your answer to it, a powerful ending.
5. **Plan your opening and ending** before you start. Linking the ending back to the opening (a cyclical structure) makes it feel finished.
6. **Write in paragraphs**, one main idea each, linked with discourse markers. Develop each point: explain it, give an example, show why it counts.
7. **Use the conventions of the form** and keep your register right for the audience the whole way through.
8. **Leave time to check** spelling, punctuation and paragraphs.

Conventions of the five forms

Form	Layout and conventions	Register and tips

Article	Headline; optional strapline (a sentence under the headline that sums up the angle); a strong opening paragraph; paragraphs; subheadings if useful.	A broadsheet newspaper means educated adult readers: formal but lively. A magazine for teenagers can be chattier. Write as a columnist with a clear opinion.
Letter	Your address and the date (if asked for); "Dear Sir or Madam," or "Dear Mrs Patel,"; an opening that says why you're writing; paragraphs; a polite close. Use "Yours faithfully" after "Dear Sir or Madam" and "Yours sincerely" after a name.	Usually formal, especially to a head teacher, council or newspaper. Be firm but polite.
Speech	Greet the audience ("Good morning, everyone"); signpost where you're going ("First, I want to..."); speak directly to listeners; end by thanking them.	Written to be heard: direct address, rhetorical questions, repetition and lists of three work well. Match formality to the audience (a school assembly or a council meeting).
Leaflet	Title; subheadings; short sections; a few bullet points (but keep full sentences, as the paper asks); a clear call to action at the end.	Speak directly to the reader ("you"). Be clear and practical. Don't draw pictures or boxes; the marks are for the writing.
Essay	A title; an introduction stating your view; paragraphs that develop the argument (and deal with the other side); a conclusion.	Formal and thoughtful. Fewer tricks, more reasoning: clear evidence and careful explanation.

Persuasive and argumentative techniques

Persuasive writing tries to make the reader feel and act; argumentative writing tries to convince them with reasons. The best answers use both.

Technique	What it does	Example
Direct address	Speaks to the reader so they feel involved.	"You have probably felt this yourself."
Inclusive pronouns	Puts the reader on your side.	"We all want our children to be safe."
Rhetorical question	Makes the reader think, and leads them to your answer.	"Would any of us accept that at work?"
Anecdote	A short true-to-life story that makes the issue real.	"Last winter, my neighbour..."
Facts and statistics	Make your argument seem reliable. Keep any numbers believable and don't overdo them.	"Most teenagers I know..."

Expert opinion	Borrows the authority of someone who knows. Keep it general and believable.	"Any teacher will tell you..."
Emotive language	Stirs the reader's feelings.	"lonely", "exhausted", "forgotten"
List of three	Gives rhythm and makes a point feel complete.	"tired, stressed and unhappy"
Repetition	Hammers a point home.	"Not this year. Not next year. Not ever."
Hyperbole	Exaggerates for effect. Use it sparingly.	"The pile of homework was taller than my brother."
Antithesis	Puts two opposite ideas side by side in a balanced sentence.	"It is easy to complain; it is harder to help."
Parenthesis	Adds an extra comment in the middle of a sentence, using brackets or a pair of commas.	"Homework (when it is set well) can be useful."
Counter-argument and rebuttal	Shows the other side, then knocks it down. This makes you sound fair and confident.	"Some argue that... However, this ignores..."
Imperative and call to action	Tells the reader what to do next.	"Talk to your children tonight."
Humour and irony	Wins the reader over, or mocks the other side.	"Clearly, the answer is to ban fun altogether."
Analogy	Compares the issue to something familiar to make it clear.	"You don't learn to swim by staying out of the pool."

Structural features and discourse markers

- **Structural features:** a hook opening; a one-line paragraph for impact; moving from a personal story out to the bigger picture; moving from problem to solution; a cyclical ending that returns to the opening.
- **Discourse markers:** firstly, furthermore, in addition, moreover, however, admittedly, of course, on the other hand, despite this, as a result, consequently, ultimately, in the end.

Worked example

> **Practice task**
>
> 'Smartphones are ruining childhood. Nobody under sixteen should be allowed to own one.'
>
> Write an article for a broadsheet newspaper in which you argue your point of view on this statement.
>
> (24 marks for content and organisation, 16 marks for technical accuracy) [40 marks]

Model plan

Form: article (headline, strapline, paragraphs). **Audience:** broadsheet readers, educated adults, so formal but lively. **Purpose:** argue.

Viewpoint: partly agree there are problems, but disagree with a ban. Teach young people to manage phones instead.

Headline: Locking phones away will not teach our children to use them well

Strapline: A ban until sixteen sounds simple. A student explains why it would leave teenagers less prepared.

1. **Opening:** anecdote about my cousin's first phone at Christmas; the adults split into two camps; state my view.
2. **Admit the worries are real:** lost sleep, comparing yourself to others, endless scrolling. (Counter-argument shows I'm fair.)
3. **Phones keep young people safe and connected:** a cancelled bus late at night; grandparents who live abroad. (Emotive example.)
4. **Bans don't work:** they push phone use out of sight; teenagers borrow or hide phones; analogy of learning to swim.
5. **A better answer:** families agree rules together; phones out of bedrooms at night; schools teach how apps are designed to keep you scrolling. (List of three.)
6. **Ending:** return to my cousin at the next family meal, phone face down by her plate; call to action for parents. (Cyclical structure.)

Techniques to use: anecdote, inclusive pronouns, rhetorical question, analogy, list of three, counter-argument, antithesis, call to action.

Model opening paragraph

Last Christmas, my eleven-year-old cousin unwrapped her first smartphone, and within an hour the adults at the table had split into two camps. Half of them stared at the box as if it were a ticking bomb; the other half shrugged and passed the gravy. I understand the fear. We have all read the headlines about sleepless teenagers, online bullies and children who cannot finish a conversation without glancing at a screen. So it is tempting to reach for the simplest answer of all: take the phones away until sixteen and the problem disappears. But does it? As someone who has grown up with a phone in my pocket, I believe a ban would do the opposite of what its supporters hope. It would not protect young people; it would send them into the world at sixteen without the one skill they most need, which is knowing when to put the phone down.

Why this would score well:

- **Form:** the plan includes a headline and strapline, which are conventions of an article.
- **Audience and register:** the language is formal enough for broadsheet readers ("tempting", "supporters") but lively, with a touch of humour ("passed the gravy").
- **Purpose:** the viewpoint is crystal clear by the end of the first paragraph.

- **Structure:** it opens with an anecdote as a hook, and the plan brings that story back at the end (a cyclical structure). The plan builds from admitting the problem to a solution.
- **Crafted devices:** a simile ("as if it were a ticking bomb"), a list of three ("sleepless teenagers, online bullies and children who..."), inclusive "We", a short rhetorical question ("But does it?"), and antithesis in the final sentence.
- **Fair and convincing:** "I understand the fear" admits the other side before arguing back, which makes the writer sound reasonable.
- **Technical accuracy:** varied sentence lengths, from three words to over forty; a semicolon and a colon used correctly; accurate spelling throughout.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Mistake:** ignoring the form. **Fix:** an article needs a headline; a letter needs "Dear..." and a proper sign-off; a speech needs to greet and speak to its audience. Check the conventions table.
- **Mistake:** ignoring the audience. **Fix:** every level of the AO5 mark scheme starts with how well you suit your audience. No slang or text speak for a broadsheet or a head teacher; don't be stiff and stuffy for a teenage magazine.
- **Mistake:** no plan. **Fix:** the paper reminds you to plan. Five to ten minutes (a suggestion) of planning gives you a clear structure, and organisation is part of the AO5 mark.
- **Mistake:** writing a story. **Fix:** Paper 2 wants your viewpoint. A short anecdote is fine, but it must serve your argument.
- **Mistake:** lots of thin points with no development. **Fix:** four or five well-developed paragraphs beat ten one-line ones.
- **Mistake:** stuffing in techniques with no real argument. **Fix:** every device should help your point. Five rhetorical questions in a row sounds forced.
- **Mistake:** silly made-up statistics ("99.9% of scientists agree"). **Fix:** keep any facts believable, or use general phrases like "most teenagers I know".
- **Mistake:** no ending because you ran out of time. **Fix:** plan your ending first and keep an eye on the clock.
- **Mistake:** analysing the Section A sources. **Fix:** you can borrow ideas from them, but Question 5 is your own writing, not a reading answer.
- **Mistake:** not checking. **Fix:** 16 marks are for technical accuracy. Leave time to proofread.

Quick check

▼ **1. How are the 40 marks for Question 5 split?**

24 marks for content and organisation (AO5) and 16 marks for technical accuracy (AO6).

▼ **2. What three things does the task always tell you?**

The audience, the purpose and the form.

▼ **3. What is register?**

How formal or informal your writing is. It must match your audience.

▼ **4. How should a letter end if it starts "Dear Sir or Madam"?**

"Yours faithfully".

▼ **5. What is a counter-argument, and why use one?**

Showing the other side's view and then arguing against it. It makes you sound fair and more convincing.

S Technical accuracy: spelling, punctuation and grammar

Where it's marked

Technical accuracy is assessment objective **AO6**: "use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures for clarity, purpose and effect, with accurate spelling and punctuation."

Paper	Question	AO6 marks
Paper 1: Explorations in Creative Reading and Writing	Question 5 (descriptive or narrative writing)	16 marks
Paper 2: Writers' Viewpoints and Perspectives	Question 5 (writing to present a viewpoint)	16 marks

That is 32 marks across the two papers. AQA's specification says AO6 makes up 20% of the whole GCSE (10% on each paper).

AO6 is only marked in Question 5 on each paper. Even so, the front of the Paper 2 specimen reminds you of "the need for good English and clear presentation in your answers", and it says you must not use a dictionary, so the spelling has to come from you.

Suggested timing: keep about 5 minutes at the end of Question 5 to check your work. This is a suggestion; the paper itself says "You should leave enough time to check your work at the end."

How it's marked

The AO6 levels are the same on both papers. **Sentence demarcation** means showing clearly where each sentence starts and ends (a capital letter and a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark). **Standard English** means correct, formal grammar, such as "we were" and not "we was".

Level	Marks	What the examiner is looking for
Level 4	13 to 16	Sentence demarcation always secure and accurate. A wide range of punctuation used very accurately. A full range of sentence forms used for effect. Standard English used consistently, with secure control of complex grammar. Very accurate spelling, including ambitious words. Extensive and ambitious vocabulary.
Level 3	9 to 12	Sentence demarcation mostly secure and mostly accurate. A range of punctuation, mostly used successfully. A variety of sentence forms for effect. Mostly Standard English, with mostly controlled grammar. Generally accurate spelling, including complex and irregular words. Increasingly sophisticated vocabulary.
Level 2	5 to 8	Sentence demarcation mostly secure and sometimes accurate. Some control of a range of punctuation. Attempts a variety of sentence forms. Some Standard English, with some control of agreement (for example, "they were" and not "they was"). Some accurate spelling of more complex words. Varied vocabulary.

Level 1	1 to 4	Occasional sentence demarcation. Some conscious punctuation. A simple range of sentence forms. Occasional Standard English, with limited control of agreement. Accurate basic spelling. Simple vocabulary.
Level 0	0	Spelling and punctuation so poor that the meaning can't be understood.

To reach the top of a level, your writing has to do everything listed for that level. To get into the bottom of a level, you need the level below plus at least one thing from that level.

How to do it

Sentence types and variety

Type	What it is	Example
Simple sentence	One main clause (one subject and verb).	"The bus was late."
Compound sentence	Two main clauses joined by "and", "but", "or" or "so".	"The bus was late, so I missed the start."
Complex sentence	A main clause plus a subordinate clause that can't stand alone (starting with words like because, although, when, if, which).	"Although the bus was late, I still made it on time."
Minor sentence	A deliberate fragment, used rarely, for effect.	"Silence."

Sentences also do different jobs: **statements**, **questions**, **commands** and **exclamations**. Use a mix.

Vary how your sentences start. Don't begin every sentence with "I" or "The". Try:

- an adverb: "Slowly, the crowd began to leave."
- a verb ending in "-ing": "Shaking with nerves, she stepped up to speak."
- a place or time phrase: "By the end of the day, nobody was smiling."
- a subordinate clause: "If we act now, we can fix this."

Vary the length for effect: a long sentence that builds up detail, then a short one that hits hard.

Punctuation

Mark	Rules	Example
Full stop and capital letter	Every sentence starts with a capital and ends with a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark. Capitals also for "I", names, places, days, months and titles.	"On Monday, I visited Leeds."
Apostrophe for missing letters	Shows where letters have been left out.	do not = don't; it is = it's; they are = they're

Apostrophe for belonging	One owner: add apostrophe then s. Plural owner ending in s: add the apostrophe after the s. Plurals that don't end in s: apostrophe then s.	the girl's bag (one girl); the girls' bags (several girls); the children's toys
No apostrophe for plain plurals	Plurals don't need an apostrophe.	"apples", not "apple's"; "the 1990s"
Its and it's	"It's" means "it is" or "it has". "Its" means belonging to it.	"It's raining." "The dog wagged its tail."
Commas	Separate items in a list; go after an opening phrase or clause; go around extra information in the middle of a sentence; go before a joining word between two main clauses. Never join two full sentences with just a comma.	"After lunch, we played football, cricket and rounders."
Semicolon	Joins two full sentences that are closely linked. Can also separate long items in a list that already has commas.	"The rain stopped; the match went ahead."
Colon	Introduces a list, an explanation or an example. What comes after the colon explains or expands what came before.	"I need three things: time, patience and luck."
Brackets	Hold extra information (parenthesis). The sentence must still make sense without it.	"My uncle (who hates the cold) moved to Spain."
Dash	A dash is a short horizontal line, longer than a hyphen. A pair of dashes can hold extra information, like brackets do; a single dash can add a sudden pause before a final point. Brackets or a pair of commas can usually do the same job, and a colon works well for the dramatic pause. A hyphen is different: it joins words, as in "well-known".	Described in words only.
Speech marks (inverted commas)	Go around the words actually spoken. Punctuation at the end of the speech goes inside the speech marks. Start a new line for each new speaker. Also used around quotations and titles. Single or double marks are both fine; just be consistent.	'We need to talk,' she said. 'Why?' he asked.

Question and exclamation marks	A question mark ends a question. An exclamation mark shows strong feeling. Use one at a time, and rarely.	"Are you serious?" "Stop!"

Common spelling and homophone errors

Homophones are words that sound the same but are spelt differently and mean different things.

Words	How to tell them apart
there / their / they're	there = a place ("over there"); their = belonging to them; they're = they are.
your / you're	your = belonging to you; you're = you are.
to / too / two	to = towards or before a verb; too = also or too much; two = 2.
where / were / wear / we're	where = place; were = past of "are"; wear = clothes; we're = we are.
its / it's	its = belonging to it; it's = it is or it has.
whose / who's	whose = belonging to whom; who's = who is or who has.
then / than	then = next, or at that time; than = comparing ("taller than me").
affect / effect	affect is usually a verb ("it affects me"); effect is usually a noun ("the effect on me").
practice / practise, advice / advise	In British English, the "c" spelling is the noun and the "s" spelling is the verb: "I need practice", "I practise daily"; "good advice", "I advise you".
lose / loose	lose = to fail to keep; loose = not tight.
passed / past	passed = a verb ("I passed the test"); past = time gone by, or going beyond ("I walked past").
bought / brought	bought = paid for (buy); brought = carried (bring).
quiet / quite	quiet = not loud; quite = fairly.
could have / could of	Always "could have", "should have", "would have". "Could of" is never correct.

Often misspelt words: a lot (two words), argument, beginning, believe, business, definitely, disappear, disappoint, embarrass, environment, February, government, immediately, independent, necessary, occasionally, persuade, receive, recommend, rhythm, separate, successful, until, Wednesday.

British spellings: colour, favourite, centre, programme, organise, realise, apologise, travelled, defence.

Standard English to watch: "we were" (not "we was"); "I did it" (not "I done it"); "those books" (not "them books"); "my friends and I went" (not "me and my friends went"); "each of them has" and

"the number of students is" (singular verb).

Paragraphing

- Start a new paragraph when you change **topic**, **time**, **place** or **person**.
- In speech, start a new line each time a new person speaks.
- Make it obvious: leave a line or indent clearly.
- A one-sentence paragraph can be powerful, but only once or twice in a piece.
- Link paragraphs with discourse markers: however, furthermore, as a result, on the other hand, ultimately.

Ambitious vocabulary

Ambitious means precise, not just long. Pick the word that says exactly what you mean, and spell it right: Level 4 rewards "a high level of accuracy in spelling, including ambitious vocabulary".

Instead of	Try
bad	harmful, damaging, unfair, reckless
good	valuable, worthwhile, beneficial, admirable
says	argues, claims, insists, admits, warns
big	enormous, vast, significant, overwhelming
sad	miserable, heartbroken, gloomy, bleak
very important	vital, essential, crucial

If you aren't sure what a word means, don't use it. A simple word used well beats a fancy word used wrongly.

Proofreading

1. Read your work slowly, as if you were reading it aloud in your head.
2. Check one thing at a time: first full stops and capitals, then apostrophes and commas, then spellings, especially homophones.
3. Look for any place where two sentences are joined by only a comma.
4. Check every paragraph break is clear. If you forgot one, put a clear mark, such as two slashes, where it should start.
5. Correct mistakes with a single neat line through the word and write the correction above. The paper says to cross through any work you don't want marked.
6. Use a small arrow or asterisk to add a missed word.

Worked example 1: fixing errors

A student's first draft (with errors)

their are alot of people who think homework is pointless, i dont agree. homework helps you practice what you learnt in class, it also teaches you to organise your time. Me and my friends was talking about it at lunch and we all said we could of done better in our tests if we had revised more. Its not always fun but most things worth doing arent!!!

Corrected version

There are a lot of people who think homework is pointless, but I don't agree. Homework helps you practise what you learnt in class; it also teaches you to organise your time. At lunch, my friends and I were talking about it, and we all said we could have done better in our tests if we had revised more. It isn't always fun, but most things worth doing aren't.

What was fixed and why:

- Capital letters for the start of sentences and for "I".
- "their" changed to "There" (a homophone error); "alot" changed to "a lot" (two words).
- Two comma splices fixed: one with "but", one with a semicolon.
- "dont", "Its" and "arent" given their apostrophes: "don't", "It isn't" (or "It's"), "aren't".
- "practice" changed to "practise", because here it is a verb (British spelling).
- "Me and my friends was" changed to "my friends and I were" (Standard English and agreement).
- "could of" changed to "could have".
- Three exclamation marks cut to a full stop; a calm, confident ending reads better.

Worked example 2: adding variety

A student's first draft (correct but flat)

School uniform is a good idea. It makes everyone equal. It saves time in the morning. It stops people judging each other. It looks smart. I think every school should have it.

Improved version

School uniform is a good idea, and not only because it looks smart. When everyone wears the same clothes, nobody is judged for having the wrong trainers or last year's jacket. Mornings become simpler, too: there is no agonising in front of the wardrobe and no argument with parents at the door. Every school should have one. Equality, it turns out, can start with a blazer.

Why the improved version scores higher: the sentences now start in different ways ("When everyone…", "Mornings…", "Every school…", "Equality…"). It mixes a complex sentence, a sentence

with a colon, a short punchy sentence and a sentence with a pair of commas round "it turns out". The vocabulary is more precise ("agonising", "equality"), and the ideas are linked instead of listed. This shows the variety of sentence forms and range of punctuation the higher AO6 levels reward.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Mistake:** joining two full sentences with a comma (a comma splice). **Fix:** use a full stop, a semicolon, or a joining word such as "but" or "because".
- **Mistake:** forgetting capital letters, especially for "I" and names. **Fix:** check every sentence start and every name during your proofread.
- **Mistake:** mixing up there, their and they're (or your and you're). **Fix:** test it: can you swap in "they are" or "you are"? If so, use the apostrophe version.
- **Mistake:** "could of", "should of", "would of". **Fix:** always "have".
- **Mistake:** apostrophes in plain plurals ("the student's all agreed"). **Fix:** no apostrophe unless letters are missing or something belongs to someone.
- **Mistake:** using only simple sentences, or starting every one with "I". **Fix:** plan a mix of simple, compound and complex sentences with varied openings.
- **Mistake:** overusing exclamation marks or using several at once. **Fix:** one at a time, and rarely.
- **Mistake:** no paragraphs, or paragraphs that aren't clear. **Fix:** new topic, time, place or person means a new paragraph; leave a line or indent clearly.
- **Mistake:** slang or text speak ("gonna", "lol", "u"). **Fix:** use Standard English unless a character is speaking.
- **Mistake:** using a big word wrongly or misspelling it. **Fix:** only use words you're sure of, and spell them carefully.
- **Mistake:** switching tenses by accident. **Fix:** pick a tense and check you've stuck to it.
- **Mistake:** not leaving time to check. **Fix:** stop writing with about 5 minutes left (a suggestion) and proofread.

Quick check

▼ **1. Where is AO6 marked, and how many marks is it worth?**

In Question 5 on both Paper 1 and Paper 2: 16 marks on each, 32 in total.

▼ **2. What is a comma splice, and how do you fix it?**

Two full sentences joined by just a comma. Fix it with a full stop, a semicolon or a joining word.

▼ **3. When do you use "it's" and when "its"?**

"It's" means "it is" or "it has". "Its" means belonging to it.

▼ **4. What does a colon do?**

It introduces a list, an explanation or an example of what came before.

▼ **5. Name four reasons to start a new paragraph.**

A change of topic, time, place or person (and a new speaker in speech).